

The Vigilante of Vordanya

Prologue

A horsedrawn carriage clatters down a winding cobblestone street an hour after dusk. Rain glitters like fireflies in the glow of the hooded lantern lighting its path, droplets bouncing off the canvas canopy, soaking into the fur of the horses and seeping through the cracks in the cobblestone into the rapidly filling gutters. A dark silhouette, vaguely defined on the path ahead, brings the coachman to attention. A soft '*whoa*' brings the horses to a halt as he unhooks the lantern from its post to better cast the light ahead.

Illuminated in the flickering glow is the body of a young woman, softly weeping and shivering in the cold. A childhood growing up on these streets tells the coachman to turn back. Where there is one body, more tend to follow. But the street here is too narrow to maneuver the horses back. Against his better judgment, the coachman cautiously dismounts, one hand on the lantern, the other clasping at his cloak to shield him from the rain.

“Get off the road.”

He mutters to her in a dark voice, slowly approaching but hesitant to get close. For all his caution, all it takes is one more step and he's close enough for her. In a blur of movement she is up from the ground, foot connecting with the coachman's ankle, letting off a sickening crack as it shatters. Balance gone, he falls freely towards the ground—head slamming hard against the soaked stone of the street, as consciousness escapes him. Seven shadowed figures join the woman, emerging from their hiding places behind the ridges of rooftops and the crates of alleyways, descending upon the carriage like hungry wolves.

The swing of a crowbar shatters the lock on the door; its bearer, a grimy balding man marked by a horrific gash across his face casts his eyes around the interior. His gaze passes over the scared face of a boy, no older than eighteen, black stubble barley clinging to his face, a white dress shirt hanging uncomfortably off his slender form. His eyes are hidden behind a pair of thick spectacles but his body flinches as if to hide behind the second rider in the carriage: an older woman, perhaps in her thirties, a defiant look from behind her gold-rimmed glasses. A smirk creeping over his face, the scarred man breaks the silence in a snide, throaty voice.

“Now, what's a pretty thing like you doing out here at this time of night? These streets are dangerous, don't you know?”

Unblinking, she replies, voice firm with as much dignity as she can muster.

“If you're looking for a handout, I should inform you I'm not one for charity.”

A chuckle is all she receives in response, as a rough hand grabs her by the shoulder, ripping her from the carriage and tossing her out into the street, water soaking into the fabric of her navy blue daydress.

“Search her. Fancy bitch like that’s gotta have something worthwhile on her.”

From the rooftops above, two men watch over the proceedings. One tall and lanky, face shaved poorly into an ugly mustache, gaze shifting every way for any sign of danger. The other, just a boy, barely old enough to shave at all, mousy brown hair and stout face fixated on the proceedings below.

At least, until a muffled yelp from the taller man shakes him from his entranced observations. Whirling around to his partner in the grips of a shrouded figure, gloved hands wrapped around the taller man’s neck as both air and awareness escaped him. A shrill cry comes from the younger watcher as he takes off running.

“He’s here!”

The six figures on the ground all look up in unison to see the shadowy new arrival and their fallen watchman. With but a single vexed glance in the direction of the fleeing boy, the figure descends into the street like a hawk upon its prey as the alleyway comes to life with the sounds of melee. Flesh slams into flesh and flesh slams into stone as bones break and eyes blacken until all but one flee in fear or fall broken to the ground.

Stepping towards the woman, still prone on the ground, the one figure still standing extends a hand out for her to take, the light from within the carriage revealing a face cloaked by an inky black mask. Clothes plain and dark save for a simple chain necklace holding a shiny opalescent pearl, the man’s piercing silver eyes match with the woman’s soft brown, his gaze softer and kinder than the ones of the man who tossed her in the rain. A subdued yet confident voice addresses her, loud enough for the boy still hiding in the carriage to hear.

“For the risk of echoing the words of your assailants, these streets are dangerous for ones of your stature. Go home. I will ensure you meet no further troubles tonight.”